

work governing marketing of agricultural produce. In fact, freeing the agricultural market would give the farmer an informed choice to produce what is best suited for his farm and also what will fetch the best value in the market for his agricultural output.

Also, on this occasion, I would like to place on record the seminal contribution of one of the greatest agricultural scientists of our times—Norman Borlaug. His sad demise leaves a huge void in the scientific community and is a personal loss to me, having known him for nearly four decades. Borlaug is the only man to receive the Nobel Peace Prize for contribution to agriculture and his pioneering research gave us our first high yield value (HYV) seeds for wheat, the very

basis of our Green Revolution in the 1960s.

Last but not the least, I would say that time has come for us to recognise that agriculture is a knowledge industry. We need to produce more from the same land and probably with less water to meet the growing and diverse needs of our population. The second Green Revolution, therefore, has to be an innovative and a sustainable one. This can succeed only if we ensure delivery of appropriate inputs and services at the right time to all the farmers. This remains the biggest challenge for the Central and state governments.

I would seek your valuable suggestions on how to take this forward in the next five years.

KAPIL SIBAL

EDUCATION REFORMS Making the System Deliver

“There is no partnership between the Centre and states. Solutions are needed quickly.”

Education is a subject which touches every person, every family and every institution in this country. So, any reform in the education sector, naturally evokes a lot of emotion, because it impacts everybody's life. Because it is such a sensitive subject, any reform of the education process must be handled with great sensitivity and care. Education came into the Concurrent List way back in 1976. Before that it was on the State List and the responsibility of delivery of education at the district and the taluka levels was that of the state government. There was a general feeling that those delivery systems were not working and by bringing education in the Concurrent List in 1976, the Central Government became, in a sense, a permanent partner of state governments in seeking to make that delivery process more efficient. The problem with education in our country is that there is no partnership between the Central Government and the state government and that is the heart of why we have not been able to move forward very quickly. Education is not about you and me;

it is about us. It is about the future of this country and when the prime minister talks about the kind of double digit growth which we hope and expect to have in the years to come, the foundation of that growth will be the high quality human resource base which is fundamental. Without that, this double digit growth is not going to happen. Therefore, the challenge before us is how to get that high quality human resource base. That can happen only if we start from schools. It cannot possibly be a top-down approach but a bottom-up one.

There are about 220 million children in this country who go to school. This is almost half the population of Europe and three-fourth the population of the US. There are about 530 million children who are less than 25 years of age. This is more than the entire population of Europe. It is indeed a Herculean task to have an education system that actually reaches out to 220 million children. One of the biggest problems this country faces is the fact that our gross enrolment ratio—the number of children who move into the university system after having

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Minister Kapil Sibal
addresses the conclave

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